China after Tiananmen, so also with India after the nuclear tests the White House soon stepped back from a serious diplomatic break. Within weeks, after Delhi promised to honour a moratorium on testing, India's Minister for External Affairs Jaswant Singh and Deputy Secretary of State Strobe Talbott were in intensive discussions on strategic and nuclear issues which lasted two years and fourteen rounds of negotiations. In the end the talks failed, but they laid the foundation for the nuclear deal with America that was eventually signed in 2005.

Entente against the US

As a result of the Tiananmen Square actions of the Chinese government and Indian nuclear policies climaxing in its nuclear tests, Delhi and Beijing often found themselves in opposition to Washington. With the US firmly ensconced as the hegemon, the two Asian powers (with others) came together to urge 'multipolarity', a democratization of the international order, and resistance to initiatives which might impinge on their sovereignty. Moscow held similar oppositional views, and in December 1998 Yevgeny Primakov, the Russian foreign minister, proposed a Russia–India–China strategic partnership. Despite its coyness on the subject of the US, the grouping was clearly an attempt to 'soft balance' against American power. Delhi and Beijing rejected Moscow's proposal formally, but the mote of an idea had appeared and would grow. Global history had seemingly come full circle from the 1950s when the three powers in varying degrees had opposed the US.

In fact, the three powers were all hedging: coexisting and cooperating with the US but trying to improve their bargaining power with Washington by signalling they could 'defect' to an oppositional coalition. In response, the US, by the late 1990s, was beginning to see India as a check against a dramatically rising China and hoped to pull Delhi to its side: with a population projected to surpass China's, a new economic philosophy after its 1991 reforms, a commitment to democracy, and the English language, it